



Qualification Programme Examination Panelist's Report

Module 5 – Information Management (June 2021 Session)

(The main purpose of the following report is to summarise candidates' common weaknesses and make recommendations to help future candidates improve their performance in the examination.)

(I) Section A – Multiple Choice Questions

General Comments

This paper consisted of 20 multiple choice (MC) questions. Candidates had to complete all questions. The coverage of the questions was widely distributed among the topics of the syllabus as follows:

- (a) Analyse the role of e-Commerce;
- (b) Analyse the risks and security of information management;
- (c) Categorise the nature and account for the value of information systems;
- (d) Describe and apply corporate information systems;
- (e) Analyse systems development process; and
- (f) Use information technology applications.

Candidates' performance on the MC questions was good, as these questions were usually short and straightforward.

Specific Comments

Candidates' performance was weak in the following areas:

- (a) Analyse the role of e-Commerce – concepts relating to customer service life cycle (CSLC);
- (b) Categorise the nature and account for the value of information systems – concepts relating to an Internet backbone;
- (c) Describe and apply corporate information systems – concepts relating to the requirements of easily available data;
- (d) Analyse systems development process – concepts relating to system maintenance activities; and
- (e) Use information technology applications – concepts relating to strong artificial intelligence (AI).



(II) Section B – Written Questions

General Comments

Similar to the first cohort, most candidates performed well with general and fundamental concepts, such as the difference between black hat hackers and white hat hackers, responsibilities of a data owner, the roles of accountants in system development projects, and techniques for addressing users' resistance to a new information system. However, many candidates demonstrated weak performance in some specific IT topics, such as omni-channel of e-commerce, identity authentication, standards relating to IT security, change management in the context of information systems, and the difference between storage area network (SAN) and network attached storage (NAS).

Specific Comments

Question 1(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to define the term “omni-channel” in e-commerce.

Performance was not satisfactory. Many candidates were not familiar with this term and provided inappropriate definitions as well as unrelated methods.

Question 1(b) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to explain why Hong Kong was described as an e-commerce “wasteland”.

Performance was less than satisfactory. Some candidates used incorrect approaches to answer this question, provided favourable factors of doing e-commerce in Hong Kong, or compared the e-commerce environment between mainland China and Hong Kong.

Question 1(c)(i) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to justify why identity authentication is important in e-commerce.

Performance was poor. Many candidates did not understand the requirement of the question. According to the HKICPA taxonomy, the term “justify” requires candidates to explain the reason for recommendation made, or underlying cause of, based on an analysis of a range of available options. Candidates should not only explain what identity authentication is but also why it is important in e-commerce.



Question 1(c)(ii) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to justify why digital communication security is important in e-commerce.

Performance was less than satisfactory. Candidates should have mentioned what kind of data or information is transmitted in an e-commerce transaction and why it is important to have digital communication security.

Question 1(d) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to list and describe any two applications of an e-business system.

Performance was not satisfactory. Many candidates were not familiar with this topic and provided irrelevant answers.

Question 2(a)(i) to Question 2(a)(vi) – 1 Mark each, total 6 Marks

This question required candidates to categorise the given application controls as input, process, or output control.

Performance was less than satisfactory. Candidates should not only understand what application controls are but should also know their classification. In addition, they should understand how to use any of these application controls in different data processing stages.

Question 2(b) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to contrast the difference between black hat hackers and white hat hackers.

Performance was good. However, some candidates did not understand that some white hat hackers may be hired by organisations to help improve system security.

Question 2(c)(i) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to justify why intrusion prevention systems (IPSs) are effective in blocking distributed denial of service (DDoS) attacks.

Performance was poor. Many candidates did not understand what an IPS is and how it can block DDoS attacks.



Question 2(c)(ii) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to justify why firewalls are effective in blocking distributed denial of service attacks.

Performance was poor. Many candidates were not familiar with the functions of a firewall, and they did not understand how a firewall can block DDoS attacks. Some candidates appear to have thought that IPS and firewalls are the same.

Question 3(a) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to state and describe two decision-making techniques that could be performed by a decision support system.

Performance was not satisfactory. Some candidates were not familiar with decision-making techniques, and some provided irrelevant answers, such as net present value (NPV), internal rate of return (IRR), or even an expert system.

Question 3(b) – 5 Marks

This question required candidates to demonstrate how information systems can facilitate performance management activities in sales and marketing.

Performance was less than satisfactory. Some candidates provided incomplete answers and simply stated common reports or business analyses without mentioning how we could use these reports and analyses to conduct performance management activities. Some candidates also mentioned performance management activities in accounting, which was not relevant to this question.

Question 3(c) – 5 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the necessity of establishing a code of ethical conduct on using information systems.

Performance was less than satisfactory. Many candidates mentioned only one of the two reasons why it is necessary to establish a code of ethical conduct on using information systems.

Question 3(d) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to state and describe any two standards relating to IT security that auditors should be familiar with.

Performance was very poor. Although a section in the learning pack lists some of the common and popular standards relating to IT security, many candidates were not able to name and describe any of them.



Question 4(a) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to state and explain responsibilities of a data owner.

Performance was satisfactory. However, some candidates just stated the responsibilities without any further explanation.

Question 4(b) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to contrast the difference between a storage area network (SAN) and network attached storage (NAS).

Performance was poor. Many candidates were not familiar with these two items as well as their differences. Candidates should acquaint themselves with the purposes of and differences between various technologies and/or IT solutions that can be used for similar purposes.

Question 4(c) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to list the benefits of using an extranet in supply chain management.

Performance was fair. However, some candidates used two different examples to illustrate the same benefit, which was counted as one benefit only.

Question 4(d) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to outline some examples of prediction outcomes that could be generated from Big Data.

Performance was good. Candidates were able to use some real-life examples to answer this question.

Question 5(a) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to illustrate how an accountant serves as a subject expert in a system development project.

Performance was satisfactory. However, some candidates irrelevantly mentioned the roles and responsibilities of a normal user.

Question 5(b) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to use any two techniques for addressing users' resistance to a new accounting system.

Performance was good. Most candidates were able to mention two techniques from their working experience.



Question 5(c) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to define change management and explain why it could be considered as a quality assurance process.

Performance was very poor. Many candidates were not familiar with this term. Moreover, some candidates used the scenario of part (b) to develop their answer.

(III) Conclusion and Recommendation

The overall performance of the candidates was less than satisfactory. Candidates are advised to familiarise themselves with the syllabus areas and their corresponding weighting before preparing for the examination. As the syllabus areas of “Risks and security of information system” and “Categorise the nature and account for the value of information systems” are essential to this module, candidates should spend some time and effort to familiarise themselves with the topics in these two areas.

As with the previous cohort, candidates are reminded to read the questions carefully and address what is being asked. Be careful to identify the keywords in each of the questions. In this examination, some candidates were not able to understand the requirement(s) of the verb “justify” (in Question 1(c) and Question 2(c)) and “demonstrate” (in Question 3 (b)). Candidates are advised to study the HKICPA Taxonomy and understand the requirements of different verbs when they are preparing for the examination.